understanding of the average engineer. The *Gallia* was also ‘most greedy of coal’. Apparently, the Parsi engineers hired to run it had walked out of their agreement after inspecting the engine. The *Gallia*’s leaky boilers required replacement, and that would cost Rs 34,000. In his view, the calculation of Rs 1.5 lakh for its complete overhaul was an overestimate. As for the *Lawoe*, its tail shaft needed renewal if it was to sail again.

Much of this biased report could be contested but the one observation that we can accept fully, without qualification, is the following: ‘There is … a strong feeling of sympathy with the Company throughout the south of the Presidency and I anticipate further financial support will be forthcoming.’ This came with a rider: ‘the company has no hope of success, unless it is brought immediately under a more efficient and honest management’. The Madurai collector, it would seem, believed that these attributes were lacking in Indians and were a European monopoly.[9]

Writing on the same date, on 24 February, the DSP, Tirunelveli, confirmed that the *Lawoe* had been mortgaged but was not sure if the loan taken was Rs 1, 1.5 or 2 lakh—it was in fact Rs 62,000. The advances had gone towards the repayment of various outstanding amounts and for new boilers for refitting the *Gallia*. However, he claimed that the *Gallia* could not go to Bombay for this purpose, as the port officers would not allow it to sail unless it was first docked in Colombo and underwent repairs, something that would add to the costs. The mortgage would never be redeemed, or so ran his prediction, and the *Lawoe* would end up being sold at an early date. The result of all these, he said, would be to wipe out the assets of the company.[10]

Company’s Response

How did the company respond to this dire situation?

In late March 1909, S.D. Krishna Aiyangar, speaking at Colombo, stated that both the steamers would be reaching Bombay before the end of the month. The *Lawoe*’s survey would be completed before 15 April, and its services would resume soon after. The replacement boilers for the *Gallia*